Afghanistan was central to this (temporary) thaw in India-Pakistan ties—both as a curse and a potential blessing. It had been a curse because of the powerful but unimaginative trope that Afghanistan is a proxy battlefield. Pakistan's support to the Taliban in the 1990s, and India's counter-balancing strategy of arming the anti-Taliban United Front, was perhaps the peak of such shadow boxing. But it had also been a potential blessing because resolving differences on Afghanistan required little political capital from both sides, and cleared the way for communicating about other ostensibly intractable issues such as Kashmir, Balochistan, and cross-border terrorism. Unending conflict in Afghanistan only fed into the existing mistrust between the two countries. Pakistan's media and retired civilian and military officials, for instance, continued to allege that India and Afghanistan's intelligence agencies covertly support TTP and Baloch insurgents.[6] Though no corroborative evidence was offered in support of such claims, Islamabad's allegations cannot be discarded in the light of popular Indian (and Afghan) rhetoric of targeting Pakistan. Indian intelligence officials, for instance, admitted in off-the-record conversations that both TTP and Baloch elements seek covert military and financial support from India and have reached out to Indian officers posted in Afghanistan.[7] India may not be the cause of Pakistan's troubles in Afghanistan, but its presence in Afghanistan did exacerbate Pakistan's political anxieties. India, in contrast, offers evidence (even if limited) of Pakistan's complicity in a series of attacks on Indian nationals, consulates, and embassy in Afghanistan via the Haqqani network, select Afghan Taliban factions, and the LeT.

But why talk about Afghanistan in December 2015 after not engaging in dialogue for over a year? Arguably, Pakistan's unflinching support to the Afghan Taliban made Islamabad's goodwill indispensable to ensure stability, if not peace, in Afghanistan, and that too on terms that it deemed favourable. Whether it could deliver the Afghan Taliban to the negotiating table both timely and effectively is a separate, but not unrelated, matter. India on the other hand, despite its heavy economic and political involvement, remained marginal, if not inconsequential, in influencing Afghan politics, making it a seemingly unimportant player. Yet, instead of being a strategic genius, Pakistan had been caught in a dangerous vortex of fire fighting that it could not sustain. Islamabad,